

CONSISTENCY, NOT CAPACITY

A case study on why Allday's wait times swing so widely —
and what standardizing staff roles could fix

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SITUATION

A small, high-volume shop running on a buzzer system

- Allday operates out of a tiny footprint, making pizza from scratch on small ovens, with weekend volume reaching 300+ orders/day.
- Orders are fulfilled as they come in and handed off via a buzzer system — there's no space to hold pre-made or pre-ordered pizzas, so orders must be made fresh, in sequence.
- Staff rotate across a small number of stations: register, ovens, salad/prep, and general cleanup (trays, tables).
- Station assignments are informal — who does what, including extra duties like tray cleanup, changes from shift to shift with no fixed system.

300+

orders on a peak weekend day

12–13

min wait for slices on a well-run shift

30–35

min wait for whole pies on a well-run shift

Methodology: wait times and volume drawn from POS/order data across 7+ months of shifts.

PROBLEM STATEMENT

The same shop produces very different wait times

Core problem: On some shifts, wait times stay as low as 12–13 minutes for slices and 30–35 minutes for whole pies. On others — with similar order volume — wait times run far longer. Space, ovens, and menu are identical on both kinds of days.

Objective

Identify what's actually driving the swing in wait times — and close the gap between a shop's best days and its worst days.

What it's not

Pre-ordering isn't a viable fix — there's no space to hold finished orders, and the shop already runs a real-time, made-to-order buzzer system. The swing happens even at similar volume, so demand alone doesn't explain it either.

Best-run vs. worst-run shifts

Slices — best-run



Slices — worst-run

25–30 min

Pies — best-run



30–35 min

Pies — worst-run

50–60 min

Same space, same menu — so what's different?

Holding space, ovens, and rough order volume constant, the clearest difference between a shop's best and worst shifts is how consistently staff are assigned to stations:

	Best-run shifts	Worst-run shifts
Wait time (slices)	12–13 min	Well above that
Wait time (whole pies)	30–35 min	Well above that
Register duties	Focused on orders only	Also cleaning trays mid-rush
Tray / cleanup duty	Assigned to one clear role	Shifts between register or salad, ad hoc
Method across staff	Similar, efficient technique	Everyone doing it their own way

Hypothesis: The swing in wait times is driven by inconsistent role assignment and technique across shifts — not by demand, space, or equipment, which stay the same either way.

No station has a fixed owner for secondary duties

A typical inconsistent shift

- Register person takes orders AND cleans all trays mid-rush
- Salad station occasionally pulled to cover register
- No agreed technique — each person handles prep their own way
- Result: register backs up, slices and pies both slow down

A well-run shift

- Register stays focused only on taking and calling orders
- One station has clear, sole ownership of tray/table cleanup
- Staff use a similar, efficient technique at each station
- Result: 12–13 min slices, 30–35 min whole pies

- The difference isn't who is working — it's whether that shift happens to have landed on an efficient, consistent division of labor.
- Because assignment is informal, good habits from a strong shift don't carry over to the next one.
- This means wait times are essentially left to chance rather than being a designed, repeatable outcome.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Turn the best shift's playbook into every shift's standard

Quick Wins (0–3 months)

- Document the exact role setup and technique used on the shop's best-performing shifts as the model to copy
- Assign tray/cleanup duty to one fixed role per shift, so register is never pulled off orders to clean
- Post a simple station chart (who owns what) so assignment isn't decided fresh each shift

Structural Fixes (3–12 months)

- Build a short training program that teaches the efficient technique observed on best-run shifts to every staff member
- Cross-train staff on multiple stations so any combination of people on shift can still run the efficient version
- Track wait times by shift to confirm the gap closes, and refine the SOP based on what actually works

Standardizing takes buy-in — and testing

Key trade-offs

- Staff used to an informal system may resist a fixed structure at first — framing it as “copying our best shift,” not new rules, should help adoption
- The “best shift” technique needs to be validated over a few more shifts before it's locked in as the standard — one good night could be partly luck
- Training takes time out of already-busy shifts, so it may be worth piloting on a slower weekday before rolling out to Friday–Sunday



KEY TAKEAWAY

The gap between a good shift and a bad one isn't luck — it's structure.

Allday already knows what a great shift looks like — 12–13 minute waits are achievable today. The fix isn't more space, more staff, or new equipment; it's making the best shift's playbook the standard every shift runs on.

What this reflects: hypothesis-driven root-cause analysis — isolating the real variable behind a business problem (process consistency) rather than the more obvious but wrong explanation (space or headcount), then building a practical, low-cost fix around it.